

How to be Heard

(Graduation Sunday 2021)

TEXT: 2 Kings 2:1-14 (NKJV) *“And it came to pass, when the LORD was about to take up Elijah into heaven by a whirlwind, that Elijah went with Elisha from Gilgal. Then Elijah said to Elisha, “Stay here, please, for the LORD has sent me on to Bethel.” But Elisha said, “As the LORD lives, and as your soul lives, I will not leave you!” So they went down to Bethel. Now the sons of the prophets who were at Bethel came out to Elisha, and said to him, “Do you know that the LORD will take away your master from over you today?” And he said, “Yes, I know; keep silent!” Then Elijah said to him, “Elisha, stay here, please, for the LORD has sent me on to Jericho.” But he said, “As the LORD lives, and as your soul lives, I will not leave you!” So they came to Jericho. Now the sons of the prophets who were at Jericho*

came to Elisha and said to him, “Do you know that the LORD will take away your master from over you today?” So he answered, “Yes, I know; keep silent!” Then Elijah said to him, “Stay here, please, for the LORD has sent me on to the Jordan.” But he said, “As the LORD lives, and as your soul lives, I will not leave you!” So the two of them went on. And fifty men of the sons of the prophets went and stood facing them at a distance, while the two of them stood by the Jordan. Now Elijah took his mantle, rolled it up, and struck the water; and it was divided this way and that, so that the two of them crossed over on dry ground. And so it was, when they had crossed over, that Elijah said to Elisha, “Ask! What may I do for you, before I am taken away from you?” Elisha said, “Please let a double portion of your spirit be upon me.” So he said, “You have asked a hard thing. Nevertheless, if you see me when I am taken from you, it shall be so

for you; but if not, it shall not be so.” Then it happened, as they continued on and talked, that suddenly a chariot of fire appeared with horses of fire, and separated the two of them; and Elijah went up by a whirlwind into heaven. And Elisha saw it, and he cried out, “My father, my father, the chariot of Israel and its horsemen!” So he saw him no more. And he took hold of his own clothes and tore them into two pieces. He also took up the mantle of Elijah that had fallen from him, and went back and stood by the bank of the Jordan. Then he took the mantle of Elijah that had fallen from him, and struck the water, and said, “Where is the LORD God of Elijah?” And when he also had struck the water, it was divided this way and that; and Elisha crossed over.”

INTRO: We live in a generation which is enamored with having their voice heard and their ideas taken seriously. Any leader who

does not recognize this is doomed to fail. The reason for this seems to be that the younger generation is concerned that those in leadership are unaware of the challenges of the future. It appears to them that many leaders are asleep at the wheel, or at least intoxicated with the systems of the past.

The expectations of this generation are much more demanding than some other generations. Their need to be heard stems from several factors:

- They feel that their parent's generation has lost its courage.
- They believe their parent's generation has a consumer mentality rather than a pioneer mentality.
- They believe their parent's generation has charted a course which has a date with disaster.
- They believe their parent's generation has placed its loyalty in organizations_ which have lost their way.

In short, they believe being heard is a matter of life and death! For them, being heard will have much to do with whether or not they have a future to pass on to their children.

Leadership is not a sprint it is a relay race. Each leader is eternally connected to their predecessor and successor. Anything I build should be built on the shoulders of my predecessor and handed gracefully to my successor. Leadership which operates otherwise is misguided and selfish.

How should followers go about having their voice heard by those who are presently in authority? For young people who have a mantle of leadership being developed in their lives, awaiting a time when they will be in charge seems to be a never-ending process. Young people can have their voices heard by following some very simple discipleship rules.

ALLOW YOURSELF TO BE HUMBLLED

In the story of Elijah and Elisha, the younger prophet knew the older man of God would soon be taken away. He did not attempt to seize a mantle which was not being offered; he humbled himself to become a servant and patiently waited on a time when his opinion would be asked for.

It is believed that Elisha faithfully served Elijah for approximately ten years. During this ten-year period, Elisha:

- Mowed the grass
- Cleaned the restrooms
- Changed the church sign
- Locked the doors
- Turned the heat and air on and off
- Drove the man of God to the next meeting
- Carried water to the podium
- Ran the product table

I realize the list of things Elisha did was much different than the list I just gave you, but you get the picture, he did whatever was necessary to be mentored by the prophet.

A person placed in authority before traveling the road of humility, will be required to travel a road of public humiliation. Every effective leader must first be humbled. If a leader is not humbled, pride and arrogance will destroy everything he builds.

One of my spiritual sons worked in a full-service gas station while preparing for ministry. One day a person pulled up to the gas pump and wanted gasoline, a window wash, the oil checked, and the tire pressures checked. When the lady drove away my spiritual son was angry, and the Lord spoke to him and said, *“If you can’t serve them, you cannot serve me!”*

Dave Thomas, the founder of the Wendy's fast food chain, said he *“Received his MBA (Masters in Business Administration) through Mop Bucket Attitude before he got his GED!”*

Elisha humbled himself before both God and Elijah and it paid off in great dividends!

BE SUBMISSIVE TO THOSE IN AUTHORITY

When we are in the process of being mentored; when we are on the journey of being raised up to our destiny; when we are waiting in the wings for God's timing in placing us in a role to impact direction, we should always keep in mind - we are not the authority. This is our turn to submit to the authority God has set over us.

How many times do you think Elijah asked Elisha to do something that was not necessarily Elisha's cup of tea or in his

gifting? What are we to do when this occurs? We are to submit and do the very best that we can for our leader! We should do everything “... *as unto the Lord!*”

When Elijah called Elisha to follow him, he required him to leave everything behind. Ten years later, when Elisha knew Elijah was going to be taken away, it was not difficult for him to stay on the trail of the man of God because he had been doing so for ten years.

Submission is not something you can pick up and lay down at will, it is not something you do when you feel like it and when you don't; when you agree and disagree; a follower is to submit to the leader in all cases except when doing so requires a violation of the written Word of God. (The dust of the Rabbi)

If we desire to be heard, we will submit to the leadership God has chosen to place over us.

SERVE THE GENERATION ABOVE YOU

Why was Elisha chosen to receive Elijah's anointing rather than the "heirs-apparent" — the sons of the prophets? The answer: Because he spent ten years serving the man of God.

Serving sounds easy enough, but it requires the following things:

- Time
- Effort
- Resources
- Love
- Patience

One cannot serve a leader without making the investment of time.

One cannot serve a leader without expending selfless effort.

One cannot serve a leader without being willing to commit substantial resources to the purpose.

One cannot faithfully serve a leader they do not love.

One cannot be devoted to a purpose without exercising patience.

Elisha committed himself to these five things in an effort to serve Elijah. He literally left everything behind for the purpose of serving his leader!

Elisha served Elijah for ten years and when it came time to pass the mantle of anointing. The coveted mantle did not go the heirs-apparent; it went to the man who had served his leader. Elisha received exactly what he

asked for; he performed twice as many miracles as his mentor. Service eventually pays off in a big way!

CONCLUSION:

William Jennings Bryan said, “*Destiny is not a matter of chance, it is a matter of choice. It is not a thing to be waited for; it is a thing to be achieved.*” Our destiny will only be achieved through humility, submission, and service.